

## 7.4. Safe Sharing On The LAN

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In Chapter 2, we recommended that you turn off Simple File Sharing on a standalone home PC. While the recommendation still holds if your PC is a standalone machine with just an Internet connection, you may need to turn on Simple File Sharing if you are on a network. Simple File Sharing is standard in XP Home and available in stand-alone non-domain XP Professional systems. XP Professional has the option of using advanced file sharing even if the system is not connected to a domain. File sharing on a network can make things much easier. For example, sharing your MP3 collection folder or your family album across multiple computers at home is a much better idea than copying the same files over and over again from one computer to another.

Note that the “Simple” in Simple File Sharing refers to the ease of use in file sharing, and does not mean that the file sharing is technologically inferior to the advanced file sharing in XP Professional. Simple File Sharing hides the complexity of managing users and permissions for newbies.

To turn on Simple File Sharing, go to **My Computer > Tools > Options**. Select the View tab and check the box that says “Use Simple File Sharing (Recommended)”.

In Simple File Sharing, users have only two options:

- Share a folder on the network
- Allow users to change files in the shared folder

It is advisable to keep the shared folder in your My Documents folder or on your Desktop: it will be easily accessible, and you can disable sharing at any time you want. To create a shared folder, right-click on an existing folder, or create a new one and then right-click it. Select “Sharing and Security” to open the Sharing tab of the folder’s Properties dialog box. In the “Network sharing and security” section, check the box next to “Share this folder on the network”. However, the files within this folder are read-only,